

modified by using the related option. Some of the other fancy effects that can be added are pixellation, embossing, inverting, and preparing posters.

Layering is a powerful image manipulation method. Those of you who are not familiar with this aspect of image editing can consider a Layer as a transparent medium placed over an image. The effects are applied to the layers, and by controlling the visibility of the layer the impact of the effects on it can be controlled. Many layers can be created, each with a different effect making it easier to manage the editing process, since working with one layer does not affect the others.

In Splashup, the Layer box lists the different layers in the image. A layer can be selected by clicking on it, thereby making the effects that were created on the layer accessible for editing. Splashup offers a Layers menu that allows managing layers—adding, deleting, merging, positioning and rotating. Besides, a Layer Effect option that includes some more effects not available under the Filters menu is also available. The effects include the Drop Shadow, Bevel, Gradient and Glow effects. Each layer can contain more than one effect.

Since normal image formats such as .jpg do not save informa-



Splashup main menu and text submenu

tion about the layers, Splashup allows images edited on the site to be saved in a unique file format which retains the work-in-progress detail. The .fxo file format is capable of retaining information across sessions. So the next time you visit the site, the details about the layers and other aspects can be retrieved.

The final image can be saved directly to an online image hosting site, or saved to your disk.

Splashup, in spite of all the potential, has an Achilles' heel—the absence of a proper manual. Simple tasks can seem really daunting with the controls hidden under layers of menus. With all this, Splashup only manages to appear aloof to most lay users seeking a quick touch up of their photos. While those familiar with